

Dimaano, Fontanilla, Lascano, Loya, Ronda

almost

someone

PREFACE

There is something unsettling about witnessing when the things you once trusted no longer feel certain.

For many of us, growing up begins with ideas we believe will always hold true: work hard and you will succeed, stay kind and people will stay, believe deeply and the world will make sense in return. We inherit these ideas quietly through families, friendships, faith, and the systems that surround us. They become the structures of who we are. But somewhere along the way, something shifts.

The works in this collection exist within that shift, that strange, fragile space between certainty and collapse. Across different genres, voices, and realities, these stories explore people standing at the edge of identities they can no longer fully recognize. A kid trusts in salvation beneath the threat of a falling meteor. A student grieves the version of herself that only existed through achievement. A child questions the silence of divine power. A boy confronts the emptiness behind devotion and authority. Another soul moves between selves, searching for a form that feels wholly their own.

Though the worlds in these pieces vary, where some are grounded in real life and others lean into magical realism or speculative imagination, they are connected by the same current: the experience of becoming uncertain of where one belongs. The characters wander through fractured systems, unstable relationships, inherited expectations, and invisible wounds, attempting to understand what remains. They ask difficult questions, often without receiving answers. And perhaps that is what binds these works most deeply together—not resolution, but the courage to remain present within uncertainty.

This collection does not aim to offer definite conclusions. Instead, it lingers in liminal spaces between childhood and adulthood, faith and doubt, performance and identity, belonging and isolation, and many more. It understands that growth is rarely graceful, as it sometimes feels like grief.

Yet within these stories is also a quiet persistence. Even amid confusion and disappointment, each character continues searching—for meaning, for connection, for truth, or simply for a way forward.

Perhaps that search itself is what makes us human.

As the collection unfolds, the fractures deepen in different ways. What begins as uncertainty in faith, routine, and external stability gradually shifts into distrust toward expectations, relationships, and systems that once shaped these characters' worlds. Eventually, the questioning turns inward, confronting identity and the fragile foundations of the self. Though each work stands on its own, they form a progression through successive collapses—and the difficult act of continuing despite them.

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by Rommel Jr. **Lascano**

For weather update: The night sky will be filled with a dazzling streak of meteor showers starting this April 20th until 26th. This spectacle of a celestial event, named Florine Meteor Shower, will be visible as early as 5:00 PM. According to the Philippine Astronomical...

The morning news flashed across the TV as I sip the coffee I bought from the store right in front of the terminal. Caffeine intake this early has been part of my routine as I added being a jeepney barker in my list of jobs. My other jobs include selling hair ties, sampaguita, and biko. However, since my Lola Rosa died, there is no one to cook suman that we can sell in front of the school across the church. It has been so hard to juggle working so many jobs just to feed myself.

By the time I finished my coffee, passengers had started arriving. It was the usual amount of people, and in no time the jeepney will be filled. As the commuters started filling the vehicle, I started hearing a loud murmur among the people inside.

“Gosh, is this for real?” a lady remarked as she stared at her phone.

“No way, this is literally the end of the world.” she added as she explained to the people around her that the meteor shower supposedly changed its trajectory and is now headed towards us. This quickly caused a ruckus to form among the passengers.

At first, I did not believe her nor did the other people. It was just less than an hour ago since the news about the meteor shower, it would be weird that it could change its direction within that timeframe. However, Mang Gabo, the driver of this jeep, hastily verified that this information is indeed correct.

“It was just recently featured on the breaking news!”

He then told us to head home and be with our family, and be sure to pray diligently so that this crisis can be averted. Mang Gabo offered us a ride home, but I declined saying that I will be heading somewhere else first.

“You should be careful, your lola would want you to take care of yourself.

He then told us to head home and be with our family, and be sure to pray diligently so that this crisis can be averted. Mang Gabo offered us a ride home, but I declined saying that I will be heading somewhere else first.

He was right, that lola Rosa would think that I should first take care of myself. However, what I realize is that it will be a nice opportunity to sell my other remaining products at the church as many people will definitely go there to pray and atone themselves.

And so I headed to the church, in hopes of earning more, what greeted me was a large number of people piling up at the entrance that extends until the end of the streets. It was easier to make profit, as people would just splurge hundred peso bills, sometimes two hundred. Along with the money I received is a look full of pity and sympathy. It must be because in these trying times, what I still think is earning money.

After earning quite a sum, I headed to me and my lola's usual go-to is Aling Bebang's karinderya. She sells my favorite adobo, which I now associate with my lola: the time where we would order a cup of rice and a half-order of adobo and happily sha We had been to the karinderya so often that Aling Bebang started pitying our situation and so she started giving additional portions to us.

Today, Aling Bebang is closed. I tried knocking on the gate door. Shouting *tao po*, but I did not receive any reply. And so I decided to just go back to the terminal. By this time all the vehicles were out of sight. I decided I will just watch on the TV, but when I opened it there was just a bunch of news throughout all the channels. Suddenly it then made this static noise, the screen started blinking, then more static noise, until it shut off on its own. Then it automatically opened but it only flashed a yellowish-white color on the screen.

"We are now heading towards there." said by a familiar voice through the TV.

"Lola Rosa?"

"Yes, apo. You should be ready, we will come down, and will take everyone with us."

Though it was eerie with its tone, I am convinced that it is indeed my lola. She told me once that dead people go and become one of the stars in the sky. I have been dreading to see lola. I missed her so much.

"When will you get here, Lola?"

"Later, tonight."

I am really excited to see lola again. I heard footsteps just outside the terminal. I know I am alone here so it was a surprise to hear footsteps. Soon a shadow emerged holding a bat, there were three of them. They were faces I have never seen before.

"Hey, we saw you earlier at the church. With buncha sold garlands. Give us the money you've earned"

"No." I firmly told them. "Lola and I will still eat at the karinderya!"

I kept on insisting I should keep my hard-earned money, but the thugs came for only one thing and that was to get the money I had in me. I tried to defend my money, until the guy swung the bat straight to my head. Everything spun. The TV still flashes that same yellowish-white screen, and static noise can still be heard. It is still broad daylight, unfortunately lola and the others will be coming later tonight. And so as I bleed more, I keep thinking that there will be no chance to see my lola again.

bZtTttT... BztTtt...

"We are coming down there, and will be taking everyone with us."



Faithful Encounter

by Gabriel **Dimaano**

Evening has settled down in the provincial town of Lucena. A good amount of people have gone home and the ukay-ukays have closed up shop for the night. Mercado Lucena Night Bazaar sticks out as usual with its bright led signage and the noise of street food vendors. Just beside this food alley is the Saint Ferdinand Cathedral Parish which is erected in the heart of the city. A scrawny boy walks towards its side entrance which is visible to anyone passing by the road. He takes out his cellphone to text his mother that he is ready to be fetched from the cathedral. He had just come from a meeting with fellow altar servers and other liturgical ministers. The season of Lent is approaching, the people will start gathering at the corner of the cathedral where a statue of Fr. Mariano Granja is covered in extravagant cloth, revealing only his head. Parish hours will be extended in courtesy of the priest who will be working tirelessly, talking to the townspeople. He is acknowledged as 'The Father of Lucena'. On the morning of Palm Sunday, the boy from earlier had the opportunity to talk quickly with Fr. Mariano.

"Does it not get tiring talking to about a hundred people daily? You have been doing this for around a century..." The boy asks.

The friar replies, "It does not matter to me. It is my calling."

The boy furrows his eyebrows, pouts his lips, and proceeds to walk to the sacristy to prepare for the first mass of the day. The same evening of that day, the boy was waiting for the last few people in line in order to speak with Father alone.

One of the townspeople asks, “Where shall I stay? My family has run out of any possible source of income and are now living inside the cemetery.”

Another asks, “Who should I vote for in the upcoming elections?”

The last one talks to the priest about his job, “Have I made the right decision? I got laid off at work because I could not handle the guilt of slaving for a person like him.” Once the last person left, the scrawny boy approached the statue.

“Is it true that the advice you give can make a person live their life righteously?” The boy stares at the cloaked figure.

“I cannot answer that, my child.” The statue’s eyes move as he speaks.

“Why is it that my father makes a fool out of the city? How are the people not able to tell that their own mayor steals the town’s money? For what is supposed to be funds for projects turns into money for his gambling—and it makes me even more guilty that he also spends the money on me. How do I stop him? I get told not to meddle with his work, but I can see the people struggle.” The statue does not reply. It nudges itself backwards and its eyes move side to side until it takes a halt and freezes.

Days pass by and it is Black Saturday. The church is open to everyone. There is an entire group of people gathered around the statue of Fr. Mariano. The boy decided not to engage in the crowd and waited for his family to finish talking to the statue. They left for home afterwards. The moment they arrived at their house, the maids were preparing their food on the table. The extended members of the family were present as it had become a tradition to stay at the family home during the Holy Week. As soon as the maids were finished, everyone gathered at the dining room. They prayed to bless the food and ate. It was a noisy setting.

The boy isolates himself in the living room corner with his food and messes around with the trinkets in the living room. His parents approach him and his mother whispers loudly: “Why do you never finish your food? We wouldn’t be able to eat if it weren’t for your father!” The boy stands up and leaves to go upstairs to his room. The mother attempts to grab the boy but the father says in a stern voice: “Let him.”

It is the third Sunday of Easter. The boy is alone with Fr. Mariano.

“I know you told them to talk to me. I heard them mention it on the way back to our car during Black Saturday.” “It will never work. They will never understand the severity of their own doing. He lies to you when talking to you” The boy tells the priest.

The father replies: “Be grateful. I am confident in my actions. You do not understand because you are young. The people rely on me to give advice. I was sent here from Spain, as a friar sent to preach the message of God, and guide people to righteousness. You people rely on me when you are at your lowest. The least I can say is that you surrender yourself to the Lord.”

It is the day of Pentecost, and also the day wherein Fr. Mariano will be disappearing for the rest of the liturgical year. The boy sneaks out of his house. The streets were dark and it was near midnight. He heads for the cathedral and climbs through the gate of the back entrance. Once inside, he stares at the statue of Fr. Mariano Granja. He was there for about an hour. Not moving a single bit. He talks to him one last time.

“Everyone has become blind.” He climbs up the display area of Fr. Mariano and pushes the statue off the pedestal. It cracks, leaving the statue’s head on the ground and starts weeping. As the boy is about to leave, he hears the crackling of ceramic fragments on the ground. Small chips put themselves back onto the priest’s lips.

“Indio! You do not know how to be grateful! Do you not see how I have helped the people? Despite the lack of understanding of the scriptures by the priests within this cathedral, I have done everything to help them and the town to understand it. Phlippinas is helpless without the work and sacrifice of us Spaniards.” The head jerks sideward.

The boy walks to leave.

“Listen! Your father is only doing what is best. The people of the town have no wisdom in handling money and possessions. If given the opportunity they will only use it for prostitution and vices.” The statue says as the boy walks away further, until he leaves the cathedral.



Equation

by Clare Ann **Loya**

There was a time when everything about me felt structured, like a system that had already been tested and proven to work.

If you placed me in a classroom, handed out an exam, and asked who would perform well, my name would likely surface without much hesitation. It wasn’t at all any form of arrogance; it was expectation. Teachers said it casually, as if it were already decided. My classmates assumed it. Eventually, I did too. I became predictable in the best way.

My notebooks were always neat, pages filled with careful handwriting that leaned slightly to the right. I used highlighters with intention. Yellow for terms, orange for definitions, green for formulas, and bright boxes for reminders that I never actually forgot. Even my desk felt like a controlled environment. Everything had a place, and everything stayed there.

I remember crying once over an 89. I sat at my desk, the paper lying flat in front of me, the number circled in red ink like it was something that needed attention. It wasn't loud crying. It was quiet, contained... the kind you try to keep to yourself because even you think it's a little excessive. I remember folding the paper once, then unfolding it again, as if hiding the number for a few seconds would change it. My friends told me it was still a good grade. I nodded, but I didn't believe them. Just 'good' had never been the goal. Back then, I thought that was what failure felt like.

My friends were constants too. We didn't say it out loud, but we operated as if loyalty was permanent. Late-night messages asking for help with homework, shared stories and chikahans, and inside jokes that didn't need explanation. If something went wrong, we fixed it together. If something went right, we celebrated without keeping score. I never questioned whether they would be there. It wasn't something I thought about. Again, it was something I assumed.

Even the future felt organized. I had plans, or at least something close to them. I knew what I wanted to do, what I wanted to achieve, what kind of person I was becoming, and what kind of life I was supposed to build.

Everything followed a simple pattern: Work hard, and things will work out. It wasn't just a belief. It was a rule that had always been proven true. The world made sense because I understood how to move within it. I didn't realize how fragile that understanding was until the first time it failed me. And things stopped making sense.

The breaking point: What frightened me most was not the difficulty itself, but how quickly everything I trusted stopped feeling reliable. The structure I built my identity around—achievement, certainty, consistency, and discipline—did not slowly weaken. It broke all at once. And once something breaks like that, you cannot force it back into its original state. That was the hardest truth to confront: the version of myself I depended on was not as stable as I believed.

The collapse did not announce itself immediately. At first, it disguised itself as a mistake.

A test score lower than expected. Not failing, but just not enough. I stared at the number longer than necessary, trying to find something that would explain it. Maybe I misread some questions. Maybe the exam was unusually difficult. I kept searching for an explanation that would allow things to keep making sense.

I rewrote my notes until the ink pressed deeper into the paper. I stayed up later than usual, the soft hum of my fan filling the silence while my laptop screen glowed against the dark. I told myself that effort had always worked before. There was no reason it wouldn't work now. But the next score didn't improve the way I thought it would, and then another didn't. At some point, the pattern became too consistent to ignore.

I remember one specific study session. My laptop was open, and a spreadsheet file was staring back at me. The columns were labeled neatly, but the cells were empty except for the topic title typed in the corner, like I had started something I didn't know how to finish. Around me, my classmates talked through solutions with a kind of confidence that felt distant. Their voices overlapped with numbers, formulas, and explanations I recognized but couldn't fully hold onto.

I kept my cursor blinking in one cell. Waiting. As if the right answer would appear if I just stared long enough. It didn't. For the first time, I considered something I had never really thought of before. Maybe I wasn't as smart as I thought I was. The thought didn't arrive dramatically. It slipped in quietly, almost gently, as if it didn't want to disturb anything. But once it was there, it didn't leave. I tried to push it away with more effort. But the effort started to feel different.

It used to feel like progress and every hour spent studying moved me closer to something certain. Now, it felt like movement without direction. Like running in place, exhausting but strangely unproductive. The equation I had trusted—effort equals reward—began to feel unreliable.

There were nights when I stared at my reviewers and felt nothing. No urgency. No confidence. Just a slow, creeping anxiety that settled somewhere in my chest. It followed me into exams, sat beside me during lectures, and stayed even when everything else went quiet.

I began to dread things I used to enjoy. I stopped color-coding my notes sometime during the semester without noticing when exactly it happened. Even the grades themselves felt unfamiliar. I found myself thinking something I never thought I would: I want to go back to the time when I cried over not getting a line of 9. Because now, I wasn't crying over perfection. I was crying over whether I would even pass.

The shift didn't feel gradual. It felt like something had been removed without warning, leaving a gap I didn't know how to fill. The numbers on my transcript didn't just change; they rewrote the story I had built around myself. Without that story, I didn't know who I was.

At the same time, something else started to shift. My friendships. At first, college felt like a continuation of what I already knew. New people, but familiar patterns. Studying together, sharing notes, sitting side by side morning to afternoon, and telling stories during long lectures. It felt easy enough to trust.

But trust started to feel conditional. There were small moments that didn't make sense. Conversations that changed depending on who was present. Plans that were made and unmade without explanation. Messages that went unanswered longer than they used to.

Nothing big enough to confront but enough to notice. I told myself I was overthinking. Maybe this was just how things worked now. Maybe everyone was just busy, stressed, and trying to survive in their own way. Maybe my expectations were the problem.

But the comparisons came anyway. I thought about my old friends, the way we showed up for each other without needing to be asked. I wondered if they had set the standard too high. Or if I had simply been lucky back then. Who changed? Was it them? Was it me? Or was it the environment that made everything feel transactional?

College didn't just measure grades. It measured everything from performance, participation, and even presence. It wasn't always obvious, but it was there. People were constantly balancing priorities, deciding what mattered most, and choosing where to invest their time and energy.

And sometimes, it felt like I wasn't part of that equation. I started questioning things I never questioned before.

The grading system... why did some exams feel more like puzzles than assessments? The ambiguity of questions that seemed designed to confuse rather than evaluate. The people around me... how did their values, their decisions, and the way they navigated everything become so different from how I would?

But the hardest questions were the ones I couldn't avoid. Who am I to blame? Was it the system? Was it the people? Or was it me—the person who had built her identity on things that were never guaranteed to last?

Social media made these questions louder. Scrolling through posts felt like flipping through a version of reality where everything made sense for everyone else. Achievements and milestones appeared on my screen like proof that everyone else still understood how the world worked. And even knowing those images were incomplete did not stop me from comparing my collapse to their certainty.

The contradictions didn't cancel each other out. They just existed together. And then there were moments when everything felt too much.

Like during one exam when I stared at a question I had studied for and still couldn't answer. It was a problem I had rewritten three times the night before. I recognized the formula immediately, but my mind still went blank. The room felt smaller than usual, the ticking clock louder than it needed to be. My hands hovered over the paper, unsure, hesitant. I wrote something down anyway, even when I knew it wasn't it. Walking out of that room, I felt something unfamiliar. Not anger. Not even disappointment. Just a quiet, hollow kind of acceptance. That scared me more than anything else. Because it meant I was starting to expect failure. It hurt. Not in a dramatic way. Not in a way that other people could easily see.

But in the small, everyday moments. In the hesitation before answering questions. In the way I reread messages before sending them, unsure of how they would be received or if they would be answered at all. In the quiet recalculations I made around people, around expectations, around where I stood. In the way that I stopped assuming things would work out.

And maybe, just as much, by the people I believed would stay. The friendships that felt constant. The unspoken understanding that I belonged somewhere without having to question it. When those things stopped being certain, I didn't just lose a part of myself. I lost the version of me that depended on them, the one who knew where she stood, what she was capable of, and who she could count on.

The grades. The recognition. The certainty of being someone people expected to succeed. The friendships. The loyalty. The certainty of being someone people chose to stay with.

I had defined myself too much by the things I was good at and by all the good that surrounded me. Because who am I, if not that? The question didn't echo. It settled and stayed. Unanswered. The space that follows: I used to think I was grieving my grades. But I wasn't. I was grieving the version of myself that only existed as long as I kept winning.

And in a different way, I was grieving something else too. The version of friendship I believed in, the kind that felt permanent, uncomplicated, and unquestioned. The kind that didn't need to be analyzed or understood because it simply was. Losing that certainty felt just as disorienting. Because it wasn't just about whether people stayed or left. It was about realizing that relationships weren't as stable as I thought they were. That loyalty could shift depending on circumstances. That people could care and still fail you, and that I could do the same.

I didn't know how to rebuild anything yet. Not my confidence. Not my sense of direction. Not even my understanding of how things were supposed to work. Everything felt unfinished, like a structure that had collapsed but hadn't been cleared away. The pieces were still there, recognizable and familiar, but they no longer fit together the way they used to. I didn't know what to do with them.

Sometimes, I still reach for the old version of myself—the one who believed everything could be controlled through effort alone. But every attempt feels artificial, like trying to rebuild a collapsed structure using broken pieces. The habits remain. The memories remain. But the certainty that once held them together is gone. The old equations no longer hold. Effort doesn't guarantee outcome. Loyalty can disappear without explanation. Systems fail the very people who trust them most. Once I understood that, I could not return to the simpler version of the world I used to believe in.

And I don't fully understand what replaces those beliefs yet. That's the part that no one really prepares you for. The space after everything falls apart but before anything new is built. It's not clarity. It's not resolution. It's just uncertainty. And maybe that's what this is. Not a lesson. Not a conclusion. Just the realization that the world is more complicated than I thought, and that I am too. I don't know who I am now, but I know I'm no longer who I was.

And for now, that has to be enough.

MY QUESTIONS HAVE CURSED ME WITH A SHADOW



by Sophia Angela **Ronda**

I was seven the first time I saw my mother's shadow swallow mine. She was smiling when it happened, hugging me tight, humming a little silly tune and letting out a little laugh, completely unaware. I watched her darkness stretch across the floor and fold over me like it had always meant to. Like I had always belonged inside it.

My mother was the first who taught me about the gods above. The gods do not speak. They haven't in a very long time, not since the age of signs, which the scriptures describe and the priests reference and no one alive has actually witnessed. What they left behind instead are the shadows: one per person, assigned before birth, measured and weighted by hands we are told were careful. Loving, even. The temples call it a gift. A mark of being known by something greater than yourself. A reminder that sooner or later, one must go back and rely on the gods. I have spent most of my life trying to understand why a gift feels like this.

Everyone has one. I know this because I can see them. Not the way light makes shapes on pavement. I mean I see them—their texture, their weight, the particular way they move around their owners. My mother's is vast and shapeless. The kind that doesn't know its own edges. My father's is harsher, more deliberate, dark in a way that has direction. Together they filled every room I grew up in, and I learned early to make myself small enough to exist in the space between.

Their shadows stepped on mine constantly. They never noticed. I told myself this was fine, that their intentions were good, that the gods had simply given them heavy things to carry and they were doing their best. I told my shadow to be patient.

My friends carry theirs in hues, not colors exactly but more like the feeling of colors. Muddled and pressed flat by years of not being examined. I have learned that shadows grow worse when ignored. That they become denser, stranger, harder to move around.

No one else seems to see any of this. I have watched, observed carefully, the way you watch something you are not supposed to, and not once has anyone paused to look down at their own. And maybe I was wrong for that. Maybe my sole curiosity is what led me to question the unanswerable. The shadows move through the world unbothered, trailing behind like something tame and forgettable.

Mine has never been forgettable.

The day my shadow fully became mine, I was woken up by loud shouts of my name. I rushed downstairs from my room and was hit by something, I don't even recall what, I try my best not to yet my mother's words after she hit me.

“How can you be such a cruel child.”

I felt it before I understood it. Heat in my throat. A shiver starting at the base of my spine and moving outward. The particular sting behind the eyes that comes just before crying, which I refused to do. Last time I cried in front of my parents, I got hit with both mockery and a plastic black hanger.

And then I looked down.

A shadow gathered itself beneath me, dense and immediate, darker than it had ever been. Both the shadows of my parents didn't move, and didn't make room for mine as it continued to grow. I stood there holding something I did not ask for and did not know how to put down.

That was the first day I understood what the gods had actually given me.

The temples say the gods are omniscient, that they know the past, the present, the future, all of it held inside them like light inside a lamp. They say shadows were given in love. That to carry one is to be longed for by the gods.

Some absolute bullshit this is.

I have tried to believe this. I have sat, kneeled, mouthed the words and pressed my palms together in the dark. The gods do not answer—not directly, never directly—but the priests say that is not silence, that is patience. That is the gods waiting for you to be ready.

I have started to think readiness is just another word for giving up asking. After all, their first and most important rule, one that is plastered on the walls of the churches as “the great commandments”: One must never question the divine.

Yet my thoughts, out of fear and utter despair, grew uncontrollable. If they are truly omniscient, if they measured each shadow before they assigned it, weighed it in hands that knew exactly what it would do, then they knew what mine would cost me. They knew what my mother’s words would feel like landing on a seven-year-old who already watched too carefully. They knew what the bruises my father inflicted would feel like as that child would waver between confusion and despair.

I do not know what to do with that. I have not found a prayer that holds it.

Was it my curiosity? Did the gods expect my questions and cursed me with such an overwhelming darkness?

I used to pray for the shadow to leave. I tried everything the scriptures suggest, from fasting, offering, the long prostration where your forehead touches the ground and you are supposed to feel small in a holy way rather than a defeated one. I knelt until my knees bruised. I asked as humbly as I knew how:

“Why is my shadow this heavy?”

“Will I really be able to live with this?”

“The shadow is too painful, May I trade it for something else, I’ll do anything!”

Begging.

“Please, I can’t live another day like this”

“Please, just tell me why I was given life if this shadow is strong enough to take it”

“Please, just talk to me...”

...

HAH how stupid was I? A mere human, a cursed one at that, asking the gods for a favor!

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Silence. Not the peaceful kind. The kind that is full of something that simply does not care, or worse, is watching, and has decided not to intervene.

I stopped praying. Not from anger, though there was plenty. The gods were simply not going to explain themselves, the shadow was not going anywhere, and in the end, I would just be wasting the little energy I had on a conversation that only I was having.

So I started paying attention instead. If the gods would not tell me what the shadow meant. What it truly revealed about these “mysterious yet all powerful” gods the churches all sing names for, I would figure it out myself.

Here is what I have learned:

The shadow grows when I am around my parents. It surges, the way water rises when something heavy is dropped into it making itself unable to ignore. It presses flat against me in the mornings before I have said a single word. It sits in my jaw, in my shoulders, in the back of my knees on days when nothing has happened and I cannot explain the weight to anyone who asks.

It rarely eases, though it does happen. When I am with certain people. Once, unexpectedly, when my friend let out a little laugh and sigh of relief after revealing something very vulnerable to me, her smile reached her eyes as a thank you. Her shadow rippled in a way I had never seen before. Almost light. Almost like it was relieved too. I stared too long. She didn't notice.

The shadow responds to things I have not yet learned to name. Not in a cruel sense but an honest one. As if a reminder of what I am carrying before I have consciously admitted to carrying it.

The shadow continued to grow, after every disdained look, every mock, every bruise. I have been trying to remove it for as long as I can remember. The shadow just absorbed all of it, all the prayers and begging, and grew anyway.

There is one method left that I have not tried. I did not find it in the scriptures. I arrived at it myself, the way you arrive at a conclusion you have been circling for years without admitting it.

“What were to happen to a shadow when there is no longer a body to cast it?”

The scriptures speak of the soul continuing after death but say nothing of the shadow. Nothing. Which means it is possible. Which means the shadow might not follow. Which means there is, at the very bottom of all my searching, one method I have not yet exhausted.

I do not say this the way someone says they have decided something. Not yet.

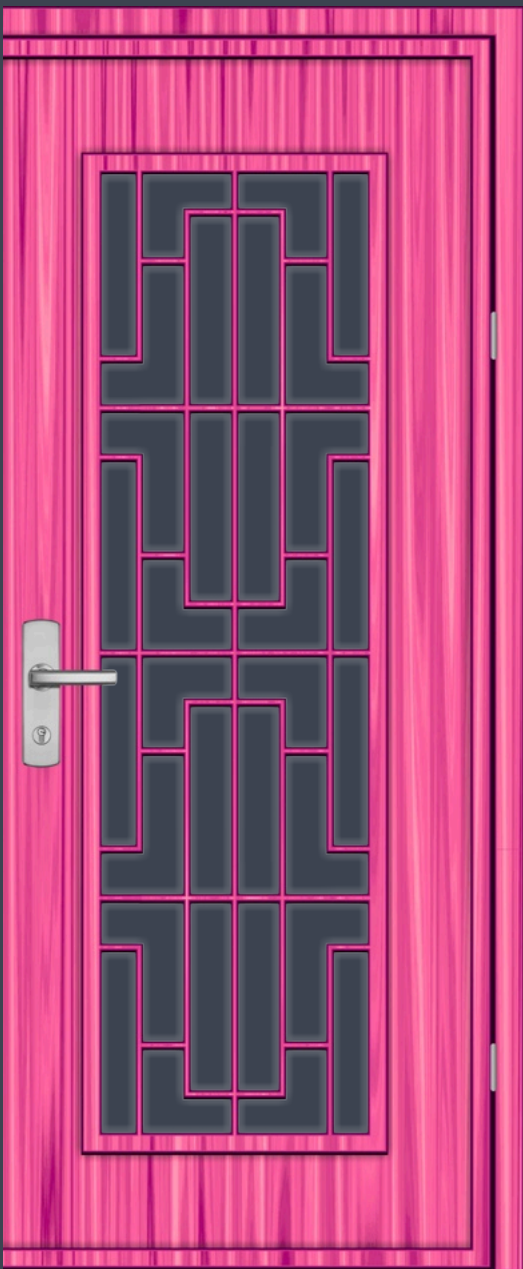
The gods gave me this shadow. They have not answered a single question I have asked about it. If removing myself is what it takes to remove what they gave me, even if the only way back to lightness is through an ending they would call a sin...

I find I am no longer certain I would stop myself.

I looked at my friend today. Really looked; not at her face but at what trails behind her, that muddy, hued thing she has never once glanced at. I wondered if she has ever knelt in the dark asking questions into the silence. If the gods gave her shadow the same way they gave mine: as a gift. As something to be grateful for. She was laughing. Her shadow rippled with it, almost light, almost free. I don't know if she is lucky or if she simply hasn't followed the question far enough yet.

Maybe we were all cursed before we were given a chance.

Oh, how the gods, who do no wrong—



Inbetween

by Niko Fontanilla

I've always lived in a dimension I call the **Inbetween**.

Quite literally, it's just a liminal corridor that stretches far to two fixed ends, with fog-gray walls and industry-grade fluorescent lights that function as intended. Occasionally, their glow carries a faint green edge I can't quite explain. The corridor also carries this unsettled quality; the space itself can't decide what it wants to be, endlessly warping into shapes unnamed.

Despite that, what I know for sure is that it's only ever held me, someone whose whole being feels *in flux*. Oh, and it also has two peculiar portals at both ends – if you weren't paying attention, you'd miss them entirely!

On the left, there's just a standard door: loud, sugary neon **pink** paint deviating from the grayish wall, the kind you'd find at a freshly opened ice cream parlor. It always looks a little too eager to exist, like it's waiting for me before I even choose to look at it.

But when I pass through it, I don't come out with the same formlessness that I had in the In-between; My voice settles differently in my throat. A tenor above what it was before. It's a kind of an unperceivable transformation. Kinda like the world adjusts itself around me. The way people look at me changes first, subtle... polite... and only then does everything else follow.

I become a boy out the door.

The guys would hang out with me, "Kai," a guy with sun-warmed brown skin, deep eyes of bronze that crinkle when I smile, and tousled black hair falling just right on my face, unassuming like the boy next door. Rather, the boy from behind the door?

This time, the door took me to the soccer field next to Makati's biggest condominium, Binay Residences. Bathed in the sun that matched my bright aura, I laugh deep from surface-level jokes about last week's game fails, and the other boys would slap my back without thinking twice.

"Pass it here, man," they'd say, and I'd oblige, feet moving fast on the grass. In all the fun I bring, no one ever seems to notice the faint seam along my jaw where the Inbetween's gray sometimes bleeds through. It happens whenever I overstay my welcome.

Once training and classes are over, coming back into the Inbetween is simple. I just have to release all consciousness in one fell swoop. Eyes shutting amid the jeepney horns and fishball steam from street carts, the corridor swallows me whole, gray walls reforming around my flux as if I was never there.

For what this corridor has in store, the baby blue door on the right end is subtler, what I'd describe as a delicately carved wooden slab. Walking through it, I emerge out of my flux as Lia, a girl beyond her teens. I find myself inside the bustling Da-Salle College's canteen, holding the sinigang tray up to my chest with confidence that cuts through the room's chit-chat.

My laugh is known to float with effortless grace, lighting smiles wherever I go. *"Girl, you slayed that presentation!"* my friends say before suggesting a spot to go to after school. Marco, the org broadcaster everyone seems to know, slides in beside me as usual. Arms nonchalantly wrapping around me as he whispers sweet-nothings across Manila Bay. I walk beside him with my soft-girl glow that feels less like something I perform and more like something the air around me holds gently, shimmering across the boulevard.

But like Kai's curse, if I linger past dusk, a bland gray shades my dewy complexion, horridly visible even in the most flattering of lights.

Despite living my multiple lives, like game avatars I can select, I actually never got to choose my names. They came with the doors, like puzzle pieces placed right where they were meant to be.

Nonetheless, I was loved for that unapologetic, conventional charm I possess as Kai and Lia. They actually drew people in effortlessly in their own ways: Kai with his easy-going warmth and Lia with her soft, magnetic grace. Yet, in the Inbetween, I am just... me. No name stuck. Nothing pinned down. Just a boring outsider whose whole being fluctuates to the pull of what I have to be that day.

"Pink or Blue today? Or I could just stay here, formless," I'd contemplate each day, just until my hunger for identity pulled me through one.

It was all slow. Day after day, I'd wake in the Inbetween and dash to one of the doors where better lives waited beyond their frames.

Pink for PE, I'm on the court as Kai. My body moves before I think – running, turning, striking the ball hard enough that body soreness can't even catch up. Each cheering of the crowd shortens my breath in bursts that feel euphoric in a way I can't explain. When a high-five lands, it's loud, immediate, deserved. I don't even question anything in my moment.

Blue for lit class, I'm Lia under fluorescent light that add to my glow. The room feels quiet until I speak, my voice projecting a liveliness that sparks eyes and draws attention. Whether they'd judge me or not, I orate my spoken poetry anyways, keeping my practiced and perfect voice steady the way I've learned to. It's amazing how each person hangs on my words, rolling in with the nods that feel like medals of high approval. Acing the assignment, I sit back down and let the silence return, just as my work here was done.

These were the lives I led at day until I inevitably came back to conceal the color bleeds. So in my loneliness, I sometimes get to come up with the randomest thoughts to fill this empty hall – *"You're so adaptable,"* a teacher handing out scores once said to Lia, not knowing Kai had perfected the same math test the week before.

Adaptable... The word itched my mind.



Fragmentation inevitably started to seep into this dual life by senior college.

As Kai, I kept getting invited to clubs, wild with beer in red cups, girls and guys leaning close. I stumble back through the pink door at dawn, buzzed and whole, only for me to feel in the Inbetween my hangover splitting my skull.

Meanwhile, as Lia, I kept dating Marco, hands locked on my waist during jeepney rides through BGC's hot streets. The makeouts taste like sweet and fleeting mango sticky rice. But when I return, the blue door swinging, I'd taste it too: the pressure of his expectations to always be "likable", which he follows up with that "good girl" label. Eugh.

I started questioning whether this can really be considered "living," until on one fateful Saturday as Kai, I got into a fight with this guy who called me soft, leaving me in community service. Meanwhile, I, as Lia, couldn't stop weeping over Marco's wandering eyes the day after. To my confusion and frustration, the corridor, once the gray within the spectrum of greige and taupe, gradually warps into what seems like funhouse mirrors that reflect my desperation for the perfect form that keeps slipping away.

More and more, as I tried to avoid my image, the reflections suddenly multiplied: Kai's sharp jaw here, Lia's soft cheeks there, my true flux flowing in between. Hunger gnawed at me. I started feeling like my skin was put into a pile of needles where the doors had marked me, pink scar on the left knuckles, blue vein pulsing on the right wrist.

The stress kept pounding on me, with the noise that held its note: *"I don't know what to be, I don't know what to be."*

In a desperate attempt to escape my horror, that night, I didn't dare staying for long at that hell of a place.

Pink first: I'm at the 7-Eleven store, buying cigarettes I'd never usually smoke, flirting with whoever I come across with. *"See you later, pretty boy,"* the cashier winks before I disperse.

Back in the corridor, the confidence that comes with superficial validation settles warm and deep in my chest. But no matter what the words were, it always fades into the same old formless void, keeping me coming back for more.

Then, blue: I sing at the karaoke bar, belting out alto OPM ballads, sounding through thunderous cheers and claps. *"You're that star, Lia bestie,"* like applause soothing my mind before the door clicks shut. I am left feeling emptier – no, blurrier than before.

This feigned freedom always came with the divide that haunts me.

Kai's held demeanor always clashed with Lia's demanded grace; her tears undoing his bravado. In the corridor that now mirrors my entire monstrosity, the fractures grew. My eyes were now mismatched, one hazel and one dark. My practiced voice failed mid-sentence. Tenor accidentally cracking into alto.

It hurts to admit, but the Inbetween, once a linear flux, now felt irreparably fractured, with something beginning to show through the gray, a tint that's hard to perceive fully. This, perhaps, is the price of knowing no proper form.



Freedom, as they call it in Reddit forums I read before on Lia's phone, meant slipping into an identity like a costume to parade. But each door boxed me tighter. Kai can't even cry without feeling ashamed of himself; Lia couldn't even speak up anymore without derision.

All because the world I know demands what they call *wholeness*. Boy or girl. Masculine or feminine. Pick a side. To appease this binary system, I had forced both while endlessly craving for that sense of acceptance that deviance just can't grasp.

But now, I was neither. Formless. Shattered across this crumbling Inbetween prison, realizing that I became *reality's defiance*.

My mind broke down from the endless switching, the soul-crushing chase for love in skins that aren't mine. Hollow notes of love I can never truly hold, not with my own hands, at least.

As if someone would hear it, "*Please, just end this fractured existence already,*" I pleaded to myself, but my voice doesn't echo back the way it used to. It just hangs there.

In the silence, something flickered. But the pink and blue doors didn't break or vanish just like I hoped. They wavered, like their certainty couldn't hold the weight of my inability to accept myself.

I waited for collapse, for something dramatic to end me. Could everything just implode with me right now? I finally accepted the cold hard truth anyways, the truth that I never belonged in this plane of rules and forms.

Still. Nothing. There remained myself and the disgust that sat beside me.

The door stayed pink, the other stayed blue, mocking me and how helpless I was about all of this. Still, I waited and waited for the feeling that something might finally settle, either the sharpness of collapse or the comfort of resolution. But neither came. Why would they for someone so ... unfinished?

The silence was deafening, almost begging me to just go out and assume either identities I've tried to be happy with. But Kai will never arrive fully, nor will Lia. They are habits I had almost mastered too well to discard, but not well enough to become permanent.

In desperation, I crawled to one end, my hand instinctively lifting itself to the door, until it stopped. Not because the door will refuse entry. Maybe because I had already done this too many times for it to feel like a choice. My fingers hovered there— close enough to remember Kai, close enough to remember how easily I could become him and enjoy the half-assed affections and frolics.

The blue door waited for me the same way it always did. Just as available, patient, familiar as Lia. Both were still there, but neither felt like an answer anymore. My hand trembled, then slowly lowered. Releasing all grip on reality, knowing Kai will never arrive fully, nor will Lia.

I just sat there on the gray, sunken floor, staying exactly where I was. Losing hope in all of my being. Suddenly, something began running down my face. A constant and steady stream. They stung, they felt weird. But I didn't wipe them away, nor did I run to either door to stop them.

These are tears. Tears of everything I failed to be. As I let them fall onto my skin, the gray didn't just fade, it peeled back. Underneath it was green. Not lush, not verdant. Just a hue of stubborn green that had seemingly been waiting beneath the paint of my performances.

I felt the pink and blue doors keeping their watch as they remained where they were. Unchanging. Judging. But their certain rules no longer mattered.

For the first time, I didn't try becoming anything else.

My breath steadied as a soft scintillation began to crawl across the walls. I stayed, and the green stayed with me, and that strange companionship was, somehow, more than any door had ever offered.

Clack

POSTFACE

After every ending in this collection, there remains a kind of silence.

Not the silence of emptiness, but the silence that follows realization; the moment after something breaks, when you are left staring at the pieces and understanding that they can no longer return to what they once were. These works do not resolve themselves fully because the lives they reflect are not entirely definite either. The questions raised throughout these stories about identity, belonging, faith, family, love, and certainty are not questions that can be answered in a few pages.

Instead, the characters leave us suspended in moments of becoming.

Some continue searching for who they are beyond expectations forced upon them. Others confront systems that fail to protect. Some discover that love and loyalty are far more fragile than they once believed. Across the works, certainty is dismantled, yet something more honest emerges in its place: the acceptance that confusion, contradiction, and vulnerability are inseparable from being human.

Perhaps this collection was never about finding answers at all. It may be about learning how people endure despite uncertainty, how they continue asking questions even when silence answers back, and how they keep moving forward through loneliness, grief, doubt, and change. Within that unraveling, the works suggest that this incompleteness are not signs of failure, but evidence of continued existence.

And maybe that is enough. Not perfect understanding nor complete healing, but the willingness to continue existing within the unfinished spaces of ourselves and the worlds we move in.

ABOUT THE AUTHORS

Gabriel Dimaano is a student from the College of Media and Communication. He is particularly drawn to creating stories related to religion and queerness, often intertwining them. As an aspiring filmmaker, he aims for people to learn and understand about the experiences of Filipino people—may it be through the colorful culture or the violent truths. He continues to pursue a greater level of writing by capturing these moments. Aside from the main medium he employs, poetry and printmaking are two artistic activities he utilizes to enhance his storytelling capabilities. He believes that these three are art forms which are accessible; that anyone has the power to use these as tools for change.

Niko Fontanilla is a creative fiction writer and poet whose works intersect human pain and self-discovery at a mystical crossroad. Currently pursuing a degree in Political Science, his words build upon each other to capture the state of human-living and the sociopolitical realities that perpetuate them, offering a critical lens on the status-quo. With a dream of making a better world, he starts at home by trying to make a better sleep schedule while imagining visions of hope one page at a time.

Rommel Jr. Lascano is a student of the Department of Linguistics of College of Social Sciences and Philosophy. Part of his inspiration to create stems from his mundane experiences, turning it into something extraordinary. He values creativity the most, making it an effort to think outside the box. His hobbies include reading, listening to music, and playing games. Currently, his interest in fantasy and other otherworldly concepts has been reignited through franchises like Avatar and Genshin Impact. It is his goal to write and express his opinion about the country and its education, languages, and poverty. Thus, this ideology is best represented in his work.

Clare Ann Loya is a student from the College of Business Administration. She is drawn to stories that explore growth and the complexities of human experience. Drawn to thriller and mystery shows as much as coming-of-age narratives, she is fascinated by both suspense and emotional evolutions. Beyond this, she appreciates capturing fleeting moments and everyday surroundings through photographs, thus preserving feelings that words sometimes cannot hold. Music serves as both refuge and reflection as she believes that 'hugot' is more than sentimentality and is a form of healing—a way of making sense of pain, longing, and change. Deeply reflective by nature, the author often finds meaning in ordinary experiences and passing moments, allowing emotions, memories, and observations to shape the way she sees both people and the world.

Sophia Angela Ronda is a student from the College of Arts and Letters. She aspires to be a visual and literary communicator. With this, she is often inspired by mysteries and horror stories that delve deep into mundane psychological horror that reflects one's trauma or daily life.